2.6.1 Contributions of early innovators in UAV technology

The pioneering phase of unmanned aviation was shaped by a group of inventors and engineers whose contributions defined the fundamental principles of drone operation. Their work focused on radio control, mechanical guidance, and automated flight stability, concepts that continue to influence UAV design today.

- *A. M. Low (United Kingdom)*
    - Often regarded as one of the founding figures of UAV technology, British engineer Archibald Montgomery Low developed the “Aerial Target” (1916) one of the earliest radio-controlled aircraft. Designed for military use during World War I, the Aerial Target aimed to intercept enemy zeppelins. Although it never saw combat, it successfully demonstrated the feasibility of remote-controlled flight. Low’s pioneering work in radio communication and guidance systems established the basic operational framework for later drones.
- *Charles F. Kettering (United States)*
    - American inventor Charles Kettering, working with the US Army Signal Corps during World War I, developed the “Kettering Bug” (1918), a pilotless aerial torpedo powered by a small engine. It was pre-programed to fly a set distance using a mechanical control sys-tem and then release an explosive payload. Though its guidance accuracy was limited, the Kettering Bug is widely considered a pre-cursor to both cruise missiles and autonomous UAVs, representing a major step toward automation in aerial warfare.
- *Nikola Tesla (Serbia/United States)*